ARU Validator — Guide

The ARU Validator lets you listen to short clips that the HawkEars classifier flagged for one species, and say whether the species is really there. Each species has its own validation database (a `.db` file). The app reads the clips listed in it, plays them, and writes your answer back into the same file the moment you press a key.

The app only validates. It never creates, copies, renames or deletes databases or clips.

1. Install and update

You need R (version 4.0 or later) and an internet connection. Open R (RGui or RStudio), paste this line into the console and press Enter:

```
source("https://raw.githubusercontent.com/tabanid/aru-validator/main/install_validator.R")
```

- The first time, a window asks where to put the app; a folder **ARU-validator** is made there. Later runs update that same folder without asking.
- Missing R packages are installed (a few minutes, once).
- On Windows an **ARU Validator** shortcut is put on the Desktop. Double-click it to start the app; a black window opens beside the browser. Closing it stops the app.
- To update, paste the same line again. Updates replace only the app's own files, never your databases, clips or settings.

After an update, press **Ctrl + Shift + R** once in the browser so it loads the new version.

2. Start and say who you are

When the app starts it asks for your name or initials. They are stored with every session in each database you open (with the app version), so it is clear later who validated what. The app remembers the name for next time.



3. Open a database

In **Open validation database** you can type either:

- **a folder that holds species folders** (for example `C:\Contracts\2026\tabanid\Tobeatic-rare`), then click **Open / Scan**. The app lists every database it finds; pick one and click **Open selected**; or
- **the full path of one `.db` file**, then click **Open / Scan**.

Browse… shows the folders on the computer so you can click your way there instead; **Home** jumps to your home folder.



The app finds each clip's sound file by looking, in order: in the same folder as the database; in a `clips/<species code>/` folder next to the database's folder; and in the folder recorded inside the database when it was made. You do not need to set anything.

4. The screen



- **Left panel:** what is open (mode, species), the score-vs-truth plot, progress, settings, and the database picker.
- **Clips:** one spectrogram per clip, highest score first. Under each: the classifier score, the recorder (unit), the clip file, and the date and time (with minutes from sunrise or sunset, e.g. *SR+9*). A clip's border takes the colour of its label.
- **Buttons:** Play, Notes and Other species, back/forward, Clear, Export, Quit, and the code buttons. Everything has a key (see the cheat sheet), so the buttons are optional.

5. Label clips

Click a clip (or use the arrow keys) to select it, press **Space** to play it, then press a code:

Key	Label	Meaning
Y	Y	the target species (**S** = song, **C** = call, if you can tell)
N	N	not the target
O	O	another bird
I	I	insect
P	P	spring peeper (frog)
U	U	unsure

The label is saved at once and the next clip is selected. **X** (or **Clear**) removes a clip's label and its notes, if you change your mind. **Alt + a code key** gives every unlabelled clip on the screen that code, for a screen that is all noise, say.

Clicking a clip that is already selected sets where playback starts (a thin line); Space then plays from there.

6. Other species and notes

When you press **O** the clip is labelled and the cursor jumps into **Other species**. Type the codes of what you heard (for example `BTNW NAWA`; spaces or commas, any case), then:

- **Enter** saves and goes to the next clip;
- **Esc** leaves the box and stays on the clip.

You can also click into Other species on any clip, a Y clip included, if another species is calling too. A code the app does not recognise is shown in amber with the note "*not a known code*". It is still saved.



Notes is for anything else. Press **Enter** in Notes to save the note.

While the cursor is in Notes or Other species, letters are text, not shortcuts. Press Enter or Esc (or click a clip) to get the shortcuts back.

7. Two kinds of database

The mode is shown at the top of the left panel.

Calibration (Sample 1). Every clip is to be labelled. These answers are used to set each species' score threshold. The app opens on **Top clips by score**: the unlabelled clips, highest score first. **Reload** brings up the next batch.

Occupancy (Sample 2). Clips are grouped by recorder (unit) and week. One Y is enough to show the species was there that week, so you only need to work until the first Y in each group. A group with every clip examined and no Y is an absence.



- The **Group** box at the top shows the current unit × week and whether it is done. **Next unresolved** jumps to the next group that still needs work.
- The **coverage plot** has one square per unit (columns, west to east, labelled with the last digits of the recorder number) and week (rows): grey = to do, red = examined with no Y, green = Y found, teal = heard in another species' clip, white = no clip in this database for that unit and week. The square you are on has a black outline. **Click a square** to open that group; hover to see its name.
- A **teal** square is already done: someone typed this species in **Other species** on another species' clip from that unit and week (in Sample 1 or Sample 2). The app skips it, and hovering names the clip it came from. **Progress** counts these apart from your own Y's.

Tip — validate common, vocal species first in Sample 2. They turn up most often as "other" in other clips, so doing them early donates the most skipped cells to the species you do later. Order changes only your time, never the final result.

8. Views

Choose under **View & layout → View**:

View	Shows
Top clips by score	unlabelled clips, highest score first
Best clip per cell	the best unlabelled clip from each unit × week without a Y (occupancy)
Occupancy groups	one unit × week at a time (occupancy)
All clips (review)	every clip, labelled or not
All clips for one unit	every clip from one recorder, across all weeks, highest score first

The view only changes what is on screen; labels are the same whichever view you use. A database where every clip is already labelled opens on **All clips (review)**.

9. Settings

- **Spectrogram settings** (bottom of the left panel): frequency range, contrast, window, colours. Click **Update spectrograms** to apply.
- **Rows / Cols / Clip height** set how many clips are on a screen.
- **Show p(correct)**: the pipeline's estimate of how likely each clip is correct. It is off by default and is for information only; label what you hear.
- **Save settings** keeps these for next time.

If the screen is too small: drag the grey bar above the buttons up to shrink the clip area, click ‹ at the top of the left panel to hide it, or zoom the browser out with **Ctrl** and **−**. The keys work without the buttons.

10. What is saved, and where

Everything is saved straight into the database you opened. For each clip the app writes only: the label, whether it has been examined, song or call, the time, and the notes (Other species are kept at the start of the notes, as `other=BTNW,NAWA`). It also adds one line per session recording who validated and with which version of the app. **Export** writes a CSV of the labels next to the database.

11. If something goes wrong

Problem	Try
"cannot open URL" when installing	check the internet connection and paste the line again
a package will not install	close other R sessions, paste the line again
a key does nothing	click on a clip (the cursor may be in a text box), or press Esc
no sound	click Play once with the mouse (browsers block sound until you click)
the old version still shows	press Ctrl + Shift + R in the browser
spectrograms say "audio not found"	the clips are not beside the database or in the folder it expects; tell Phil where they are